

Calomys laucha

Little lauca



Length 2¾ in (7 cm)
Tail 2¼ in (5.5 cm)
Weight 7/16 oz (13 g)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location C. and E. South America



The little lauca resembles the house mouse (see p.128) not only in appearance but also in living near human dwellings and in its occasional population surges, when it may become a pest. It is gray-white above and pale to dark brown on the underside, with a white patch behind each medium-sized ear, and a long, sparsely furred tail. It builds a grassy nest in any crevice, such as under a log, rock, floorboards, or even—being a skillful climber—in a tree fork. The main diet is plants of all kinds, supplemented by a few insects such as beetles and caterpillars.

Phodopus roborovskii

Roborovski's desert hamster



Length 2¼–4 in (5.5–10 cm)
Tail 2¼–4¼ in (7–11 cm)
Weight 7/16–1¼ oz (25–50 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location E. Asia



Also called the dwarf hamster, this small, short-tailed, prominent-eared rodent is pale brown on its upperparts with pure white underparts. Its rear feet are short and broad, with dense fur on the underside for jumping across hot, loose desert sand. Like other hamsters, the Roborovski's desert hamster crams seeds into its internal cheek pouches and takes them back to its burrow for storage. It also eats insects such as beetles, locusts, and earwigs. The nesting burrow is dug in firm sand and is lined with hair shed by camels and sheep.



Sigmodon hispidus

Hispid cotton rat



Length 5–8 in (13–20 cm)
Tail 3¼–6½ in (8–16.5 cm)
Weight 3¾–8 oz (100–225 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location S. USA



This is one of 14 cotton rat species in the Americas. Some are extremely rare, others locally numerous, even increasing to pest status when food is plentiful. The hispid cotton rat feeds



on many foods, including plants (sometimes ruining crops such as sweet potato and sugar cane), insects, and grubs. Being a good swimmer, it also takes freshwater crabs, crayfish, and frogs, and climbs reeds to eat birds' eggs and chicks. It is active day and night, usually living alone in a grassy nest in a sheltered depression in the ground or in a burrow up to 30 in (75 cm) deep. The hispid cotton rat digs a shallow burrow as it feeds, and establishes well-worn foraging runways. Its stiff fur is brown to brownish gray on the back, gray-white underneath. The female becomes sexually mature at 6–8 weeks, and, after 27 days' gestation, she gives birth to up to 10 young.

Mesocricetus auratus

Golden hamster



Length 5–5½ in (13–13.5 cm)
Tail ½ in (1.5 cm)
Weight 3¾–4 oz (100–125 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable

Location W. Asia



The golden hamster, familiar around the world as a pet, is restricted in the wild to a small area of western Asia. Its golden coat may show a darker patch on the forehead and a black stripe from

each cheek to the upper neck. The fur pales to gray-white on the underside. Grooming is important to keep the coat in good condition, and both front teeth and claws are used for this purpose. This hamster excavates a burrow down to 6½ ft (2 m), which it rarely leaves except to feed on a diet of seeds, nuts, and small creatures such as ants, flies, cockroaches, bugs, and even wasps. It is aggressive toward other hamsters.

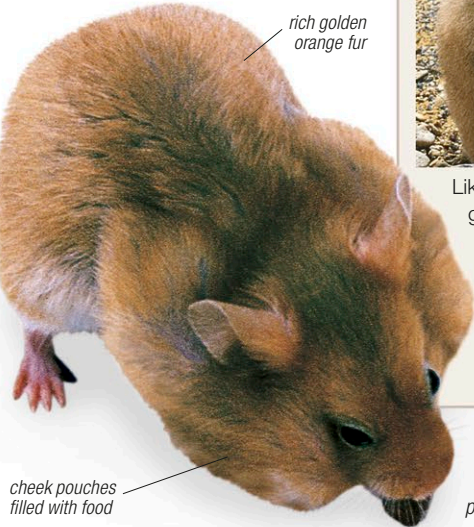
SOLITARY GROOMING



Like many other hamsters, the golden hamster lives alone, so it has to rid its own coat of dirt, old fur, tangles, and pests such as fleas, rather than relying on mutual grooming like many social rodents.

ROBUST RODENT

The golden hamster has a blunt muzzle, broad face, small eyes, prominent ears, and tiny tail.



rich golden orange fur

cheek pouches filled with food

Kunsia tomentosus

Giant South American water rat



Length 11½ in (29 cm)
Tail 6 in (15 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location C. South America



A little-known species, this large, small-eared, short-tailed rat spends much time burrowing, using its strong feet equipped with long, curved claws. Its upper fur is dark brown with stiff hairs, and the underneath hairs are gray with white tips. As the giant South American water rat tunnels, it consumes roots, tubers, and other underground plant parts. During the flood season, however, water fills its tunnels, so this rat stays mainly above ground, where its diet changes to mostly grasses and shoots.

Cricetus cricetus

Common hamster



Length 8–13½ in (20–34 cm)
Tail 1½–2¼ in (4–6 cm)
Weight 3¾–32 oz (100–900 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location Europe to C. Asia



The largest hamster, this species has distinctively thick fur, which is red-brown on the back and mainly black on the underside, with white patches on the nose, cheeks, throat, flanks, and paws—darker underside coloration compared to the upperparts is very unusual among mammals. In autumn, the common hamster hoards seeds, roots, and other plant matter, carrying items in its large, external cheek pouches back to its burrow. It then hibernates until spring, waking every 5–7 days to feed. In summer, it also eats grubs, worms, and other creatures. After 18–20 days' gestation, the female produces a litter of up to 12, which are weaned by 3 weeks and fully grown by 8 weeks.

